By 1862 the factories of the North were gearing up to supply the expanding army with standard uniforms and equipment, which were soon in far better supply for the Union soldier than for the Southerner. Improved training and daily drill gave the troops a more soldierly look. The election of officers was gradually phased out and many inefficient commanders were sacked. Yet discipline often remained poor compared with contemporary European armies. Most Americans had no natural sense of obedience to authority. Soldiers were conscious of being citizens with rights – or were just downright obstinate. One private complained bitterly of officers seeming to "consider themselves as made of a different material from the low fellows in the ranks".

SOCIAL ORIGINS

The Union soldier was most likely to be from a farming background or an urban artisan. Mostly in their twenties, the troops reflected the diversity of Northern society. One in five Union soldiers was of German origin, with the Irish the next largest ethnic group. Around ten per cent of the army were recent immigrants from Europe.

African Americans were initially banned from enlistment, but mounting manpower shortages necessitated a change of policy during 1862 – though they were not granted equal pay until June 1864. Black soldiers were used first in labour battalions, but were then formed into "coloured" regiments under white officers.



African-American soldiers
The band of the 107th US Colored Infantry poses at Fort Corcoran, Virginia in 1865. African-American soldiers suffered disproportionately high casualties in the Civil War: approximately one-third of black Union soldiers lost their lives during the conflict.

Mostly escaped slaves – known as "contrabands" – the black soldiers encountered vicious prejudice from many Union troops, as well as especially harsh treatment from the Confederates. But their performance eventually won them a grudging respect and substantially influenced white opinion in the North in favour of emancipation. By the end of the war, African-American soldiers constituted around ten per cent of the Union army.

EXPERIENCE OF WAR

During the first two years of the war the Union forces suffered many defeats and setbacks, but in July 1863 victories at Gettysburg in the eastern theatre and Vicksburg in the west shifted the balance decisively against the Confederates. From then onward the South could only fight to prolong the conflict, rather than to win it.

The Civil War has sometimes been described as the first "modern war", with emphasis on innovations such as the use of trains for transport and the telegraph for communications. But for the ordinary soldier the experience of military life had nothing especially modern about it. Once away from a rail depot he moved on foot, often over substantial distances. Inevitably a soldier had a heavy pack and weapon to carry, a burden he was always seeking to lighten – the route of a march was usually littered with discarded blankets and other kit. Unless strict discipline was enforced, stragglers would fall by the wayside in droves. Although food supplies in the Union army were

Camp life
A Union encampment at Cumberland Landing on the Pamunkey River in 1862. Soldiers usually slept under canvas in conical Sibley tents or increasingly, as the war dragged on, in smaller wedge tents.